

**Unveiling The Unknown : An Experience of
The Grim Realities of The Society**

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Education, Origins and More : An Overview of Myself

I am Amrita Ray from Raiganj, West Bengal. I was born and brought up in the same place. I have been on the journey of Gandhi Fellowship from August, 2024.

1.1.1 Education:

- Secondary education: Passed out in 2018 from WBBSE
- Higher Secondary: 2021 from WBCHSE
- Graduation: B.A in sociology in 2024 from Raiganj University

1.1.2 Work Experience:

- Have been working in the modelling industry for the last 5 years.
- Worked as an Anchor for 2 years
- Was home tutor for 4 years
- Worked in an NGO for 2 years.

1.1.3 Hobby:

Dance
Acting
Singing
Reading
Writing
Travelling

1.1.4 Personality:

I believe human changes with every moment and events that take place in life. So, what I am today, I wasn't in my past and I won't be that in the next upcoming years. So, the personality that I hold is only for the present. I become a philosophical person when it comes to understanding life. I am always a curious person who questions everything around her and that's how I build perspectives about things. With all these things I try to become a person who is useful to others because I believe 'Human in need is a human indeed'. Here I am not using the word 'good' as it's a very subjective word.

I am also connected with nature very much and here my thought is that the human body is made up of five elements, so in order to know oneself or to dig deep in one's own self, the person needs to connect himself with nature.

I love to enjoy every moment and when I say 'enjoy', I don't mean to be happy all the time. I mean even when I am sad or lost, I enjoy that sadness too by laying on the bed the whole day or scrolling the phone or watching Netflix.

With all these things I am someone who is always passionate about what she does. So, I always try to give my best and I do give my best.

1.2 Journey to Gandhi Fellowship

Before putting down the reason behind my joining in Gandhi Fellowship, I am mentioning a story which needs to be known in order to know me as well.

1.2.1 From Raiganj to PSL

First I would like to write about how I got to know about the Gandhi Fellowship.

Few months back when I was in my 5th semester of college, I was preparing for CUET for my master's but coincidentally the dates of the CUET exam and my 5th semester exam were scheduled on the same day. That time I had to attend my 5th semester exam, so I missed CUET. Only a few months were left until the completion of my graduation and I was worried about what to do after graduation as I have missed CUET. So, I talked with my professor to get to know about other options regarding master's. There she mentioned BHU. The other day at around 1:30 am I was going through the website of BHU and I noticed Gandhi Fellowship in their digital notice board. There I found that only 2 days were left for the form fill ups. So, I talked one day to research about it and without any second thought I registered myself for the Fellowship.

Now here comes my thoughts and emotions. I wasn't sure about this Fellowship if it is true because I haven't ever heard about such a thing before nor did I find many videos or anything as a proof. I had thought that the registration cost wasn't much so there was no harm in registering. And then after the whole process of selection I landed at the PSL in Rajasthan for my central induction.

1.2.2 Purpose to Join Fellowship

The reasons are quite simple as to why I joined this Fellowship. These reasons are also the reflections of what I want and how I am.

Since my childhood I have always wanted to study outside of my city or state to have better opportunities but it never happened because of my family conditions and financial conditions. Besides that, I am always eager to visit other parts of India and the world. And my educational background also influenced me to understand the culture of the different societies. During my college days I have built a huge desire to lead my life in a way which will not only benefit me but also the society, environment and animals. I have discovered my visions, goals and dreams. But to accomplish everything the first step for me was to move outside of my city or state.

The things that grabbed my attention in Gandhi Fellowship are-

- It gives a chance to step outside of one's own state.

- It gives a platform to know about the other parts of the country.
- It also helps to grow as a person.
- It helps to gain knowledge and experience about the social problems as well as their solutions.
- It gives a platform to explore oneself.

In addition it also provides stipend which helps the fellows to live on their own. This approach also helped me to decide if I should go for it.

1.3 Brief Introduction to the Community

The community at GP Karian with which I engaged, has few tribal households. Most of the households are of general category. This place is filled with mostly Hindus and then Muslims and the rest are Sikhs. People here don't speak the same language as they belong from different regions of Chamba. So, this place is a mixture of different groups of people from different regions and cultures.

Their primary sources of income included working in local construction labor, managing small shops, or supporting other businesses. Some individuals pursue private labor opportunities, while others find work through government schemes and few people own their own shops or businesses and few do government jobs.

Chapter 2

Key Themes Explored

2.1 Deconditioning

Before mentioning about my challenges I would briefly introduce the family I chose for my CI

Introduction of the family

The house where I stayed for my CI, is filled with 11 members including 3 children. Being a Muslim family they practice traditional thoughts and beliefs of their religion. Though they live in Chamba, they have their origins in Kashmir. So they also practice the culture of Kashmir in the form of food habits, celebrations, etc.

Three of them are engaged with private jobs, one is Maulvi and they also have a day to day job of distributing newspapers to households.

Coming from a completely different background in terms of both landscape and culture, this experience offered me a transformative perspective. The CI process was not just about observing their lives but truly living alongside them, sharing in their joys and challenges.

I approached this experience with a blank slate, ready to unlearn and relearn. I was aware that it might be a little tough for me. So, I was prepared for it with an open mind and heart.

2.1.1 Challenges

- Staying in a house with 11 people and sharing a single washroom was an adjustment. From the child to the oldest person of the house share the same washroom. So, sometimes using the washroom became a matter of inhygiene for me.
- It was a Muslim household, and coming from a different religious background, I initially found it challenging to align with their practices and bond with them. Discussions around religion and their perspectives on women used to make me feel that they are not respectful of women. And in those situations I used to stay silent and only listen to what they say.
- As a vegetarian, living in a household where non-vegetarian food was oftenly cooked also posed a challenge. So, we mutually decided that whenever they would cook non-veg, they would let me know, so that I could cook my food before them and keep it aside.
- Inequality between the women and men in the household was provoking for me. So, sometimes managing my own emotions was challenging for me.

But over time, I became more adaptive, learning to embrace contrasting opinions and lifestyles with an open mind.

2.1.2 Key Lessons

For me adjusting with and adapting everything or building empathy are not my key lessons. But emotionally, mentally I learned a few things. Not that I did it and something went wrong and then I learned. I learned these key lessons by reflecting on my emotions, the situations and myself.

- Be a good listener and a keen observer—not everything is explicitly communicated.
- Take nothing personally. Understand and analyze situations rationally.
- Empathy is about understanding others; it's not about you but about them.
- Many things are not in control. So, sometimes taking any action can make situations worse.

2.2 Understanding the Panchayati Raj Institution

Role of the Panchayat in Community Guidance

I understand that the Panchayat serves as a mediator between the government and the community, bridging gaps and ensuring effective communication and services. Things that I have understood are-

- The relationship between the Panchayat and the community.
- Different schemes of the government such as MGNREGA, PMAY, etc.
- How these schemes are implemented on the ground level.
- The ecosystem of Panchayat.
- The problems that Panchayat faces.
- The system Panchayat works for the solutions of problems of the community.
- The services that the Panchayat provides to the community.

Through my interactions with the Panchayat, I gained deeper insights into the community's challenges and the Panchayat's own struggles in addressing them. While they generate solution-oriented insights, they often lack the necessary resources for execution. For instance GP Karian faces a major problem of waste management. Though they have planned about the solution they are facing challenges regarding resources in order to make a sustainable plan.

2.3 Engaging in Labor Work

Tasks Participated In

- Distributed newspapers.
- Assisted with agricultural activities, including learning to cultivate garlic.
- Worked in Cowshed, fed the cows, cleaned the cow dung.

Fostering Empathy and Understanding

Except for the newspaper distribution the tasks that I mentioned above are assigned with the women. Even every task of the household is divided between men women. For instance men won't

go to the kitchen and cook, it doesn't matter if the women are busy or unwell. Same as women are not allowed to do jobs. This situation in the house ripped my heart out.

One of the women was 8 months pregnant when I stayed there. But she has to do everything starting from cleaning, cooking, cultivating, cleaning the cow shed, carrying heavy things to sleeping at the last. There were times when her husband was doing nothing but scrolling on the phone.

To be candid, I already had a foundational understanding of human behaviors and empathy. But this experience reinforced my perspective and enhanced my empathy.

Skills and Insights Learned

- The biggest insight that I gained is that though people talk about women empowerment, there are many places where women are still exploited if not physically but emotionally and mentally.

The other basic things are-

- Learned the process of garlic cultivation.
- Gained practical insights into the community's daily struggles and resilience.

2.4 Building Relationships with the Community

Examining Experiences as an Insider and Outsider

Immersing myself in the community required navigating the dual role of an observer and participant. As an outsider, I initially struggled with understanding the unspoken norms and cultural nuances. However, actively engaging in daily activities and open conversations helped bridge this gap. Participating in their labor tasks, sharing meals and discussing perceptions and beliefs allowed me to connect on a personal level and transition from being a mere observer to becoming a trusted member of the community.

Communication Strategies and Relationship Building

To establish trust, I focused on listening attentively and showing genuine interest in their stories and experiences. I adopted a collaborative approach by involving community members in discussions about their challenges and potential solutions. Specific actions like assisting in household chores and agricultural work, combined with consistent and respectful communication, helped break down initial barriers and foster mutual respect.

Highlighting Key Actions

- Actively participating in community labor and cultural events.
- Respecting their traditions and adapting to their lifestyle.
- Maintaining a humble and open-minded demeanor to encourage meaningful exchanges.

- Staying calm in the situations where something unfair was happening.

2.5 Acclimatization

Physical Challenges

During my 30-day community immersion, adjusting to the physical environment was one of the most immediate and challenging aspects of the experience. Coming from a different lifestyle, where the physical comforts and hygiene practices are vastly different, I found it difficult to adapt to the lifestyle of the family I stayed with.

- One of the primary challenges was the food. The food was not only different in terms of flavor but also in its preparation and timing. I had to accustom myself to eating the same food as the family, often consisting of completely different foods which I have not even seen before. This change, though an essential part of the immersion, initially caused digestive issues as my body struggled to adjust to the new diet. The food often led to discomfort, but I had to persevere, reminding myself of the importance of embracing the experience and understanding the community's lifestyle.
- Additionally, the daily schedule of the household was very different from what I was used to. The family woke up early, often before sunrise, and their entire day was structured around household chores, agricultural work, and family care. I had to adapt to this demanding schedule and could no longer rely on the leisurely pace I was accustomed to. Working with the family in the fields, cleaning, and taking part in their daily activities was physically exhausting, yet it was crucial for me to integrate fully into their world.
- Another physical challenge was sharing the single, common washroom with the 11 members of the household. I had to adjust to the lack of privacy and cleanliness standards that I was used to, and at times, this became uncomfortable. I learned how to navigate this shared space with patience, humility, and a deep sense of respect for the family's practices, despite the inconvenience.

Overall, the physical challenges of this immersion were not just about discomfort or adjusting to new routines; they taught me the value of resilience, empathy, and the significance of embracing another person's way of life.

Emotional Challenges

The emotional challenges I faced during this immersion were perhaps the most profound and difficult to process. From the very beginning, I felt a deep sense of discomfort as I witnessed the inequities and injustices that existed within the family, particularly regarding gender roles. The women in the household, despite being the backbone of the family, were often burdened with all household chores and responsibilities, regardless of their physical or emotional well-being. The expectations placed on them were immense, and the emotional weight of their duties was palpable.

- One of the most challenging experiences was seeing how one of the women, who was heavily pregnant, continued to work tirelessly in the fields and manage the household chores without any respite. She was expected to carry on as if she were not carrying a life inside her. I was deeply disturbed by the apparent lack of concern for her well-being. The pervasive attitude that women, regardless of their condition, must perform these tasks without complaint left me feeling helpless and angry.
- As I interacted with members of the community, I also came across several stories of hardship that left me emotionally drained. I met individuals who had been deeply affected by poverty, violence, and systemic neglect. Hearing these stories was a stark reminder of the harsh realities that many people face, and it made me feel powerless. There was a recurring sense of frustration, as I could not change their circumstances or alleviate their suffering in any meaningful way. This powerlessness, combined with the overwhelming emotions of empathy, left me feeling numb and distant at times. It was difficult to reconcile my own position as an outsider who could only witness but not alter the trajectory of their lives.
- Also the family being of a different religion was only respectful to their own beliefs. Sometimes they made fun of the religion to which I belong. I couldn't say anything that was really hurtful.

The emotional toll of these experiences was not just about sympathy—it also involved confronting my own privilege and acknowledging the discomfort that arose from being in a situation where I could not "fix" what was wrong. Over time, I learned that the role I had to play was not one of a savior, but of someone who listened, observed, and understood without offering quick solutions. This experience was humbling, but it also served as a catalyst for deeper reflection on the complexities of social change and the challenges of addressing inequality in marginalized communities.

Social Challenges

Socially, one of the most significant challenges was navigating the complex dynamics of the community. As an outsider, there was an inherent barrier between me and the people I was interacting with. The community had its own customs, norms, and systems of hierarchy, and I had to learn how to navigate these in a respectful and sensitive manner. It was often difficult to break through the social barriers, particularly because I was perceived as an outsider with a different background. Although the family was warm and welcoming, I could not escape the sense of being different, which made me feel isolated at times.

The most challenging aspect was integrating into the social fabric of the community, which was based heavily on shared histories, traditions, and close-knit familial bonds. In many ways, I felt like an outsider who would never truly belong, no matter how much I tried to adapt. There were certain social norms that were hard for me to accept, especially in terms of how people interacted with each other, particularly across gender lines. The rigid roles assigned to men and women in the

community were not only a reflection of patriarchal values but also reinforced by generations of cultural practices. This dynamic often left me questioning the broader societal structures at play and feeling conflicted about my role within this system.

Moreover, I faced difficulty in establishing rapport with individuals outside the immediate family. The process of communicating and connecting with community members who were often more reserved or distrustful of outsiders was not always smooth. Some were hesitant to share their stories or open up to someone they perceived as a "visitor" rather than a true part of the community. There were instances when I felt socially alienated, despite my best efforts to integrate. I had to constantly remind myself to be patient and respect the community's pace in building trust.

Furthermore, I encountered instances where cultural differences in communication and behavior led to misunderstandings. Simple actions or words that seemed innocent to me could be misinterpreted, and I sometimes felt I was walking on eggshells, worried that my presence or actions might offend someone unintentionally. Balancing the need to be respectful while staying true to my own values was a delicate act.

Despite these social challenges, the experience ultimately taught me the importance of empathy and understanding. It helped me appreciate the deep-rooted values of community life and the complexities of social interactions within marginalized settings. While I did not always feel fully integrated, the experience broadened my understanding of social dynamics and the complexities of building genuine relationships in unfamiliar environments.

Effects on Community Interactions

The community immersion (CI) process had a profound impact on me, both personally and professionally. It deepened my understanding of social realities and sharpened my empathy, enabling me to connect with people on a deeper level. By living alongside the family, I gained firsthand insight into the struggles and resilience of individuals in marginalized communities. This experience strengthened my ability to see beyond surface-level perceptions and recognize the complexities of socio-economic and cultural factors shaping people's lives.

On a personal level, the CI process challenged my abilities and made me more adaptable and resourceful. I learned to step outside my comfort zone, navigate discomfort, and appreciate the value of simple living. It also helped me develop a heightened sense of gratitude for the privileges I had previously taken for granted, such as access to better living conditions and resources, privileges to do what I want.

Professionally, the experience broadened my perspective on community development and social change. It gave me a more grounded understanding of the real-world challenges faced by disadvantaged communities, which I can now apply to my work with a more informed and empathetic approach. Ultimately, the CI process transformed me into a more thoughtful, compassionate, and reflective individual.

These challenges initially made interactions cautious and reserved. However, facing these obstacles head-on fostered empathy and a deeper appreciation for their resilience. Acknowledging and adapting to their way of life allowed for more authentic connections and meaningful exchanges.

Conclusion

This fellowship has been a transformative journey that bridged the gap between theory and reality, enabling me to witness the profound depth of human resilience and resourcefulness. Immersing myself in the community taught me invaluable lessons about adaptability, empathy, and the importance of a listening ear. By stepping out of my comfort zone, I not only learned about the challenges faced by rural communities but also discovered my own capacity to grow and adapt in unfamiliar settings.

The relationships I built with the community—grounded in mutual respect and trust—were the cornerstone of this experience. Engaging in their daily lives and contributing in small yet meaningful ways gave me a deeper understanding of their struggles and aspirations. It reinforced the power of collaboration and the significance of cultural exchange in fostering understanding and unity.

The physical and emotional challenges of acclimatization were not obstacles but opportunities to grow stronger and more empathetic. These experiences provided a fresh lens through which I view societal structures and the diverse ways people find happiness and contentment. They reminded me that while resources and circumstances may differ, the core human spirit remains universally resilient.

Above all, this journey reaffirmed my commitment to giving back and contributing to societal progress. It showed me that change begins with understanding—and understanding starts with listening. As I move forward, I carry with me the lessons, connections, and insights from this fellowship, determined to continue working towards meaningful impact, one small step at a time.